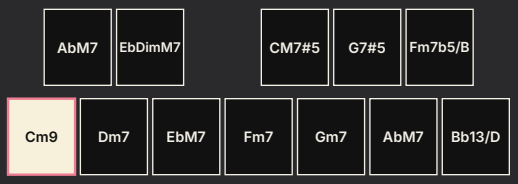
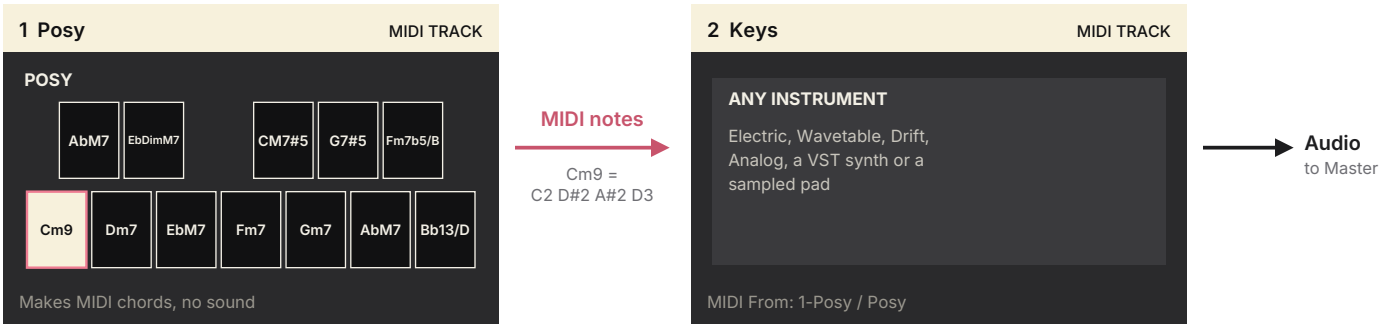
POSY

Getting started: playing chords in Ableton Live



Set 072, Neo Soul, playing Cm9

Posy is a chord generator that makes MIDI, not sound. It holds a set of twelve chords, one for each key of the octave, and plays them on an instrument on another track: one finger, one chord. This guide wires it to an instrument in about five minutes, then shows you round the panel.



Two MIDI tracks. Posy plays; the instrument track listens to it and makes the sound.

You'll need

- Ableton Live 11 or 12 (any edition that can load VST3 plug-ins).
- Posy built and installed. Building it copies **Posy.vst3** into ~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3 for you; a release download goes in the same folder.
- An instrument that plays chords: any of Live's synths, an electric piano, a sampled pad, a VST.

> **Why two tracks?** In Live, a plug-in's MIDI output can't feed an instrument further along the same track. So Posy gets a track of its own, and the instrument's track listens to it.

Set up

1 Let Live see Posy

Open **Live → Settings** (⌘,) and choose the **Plug-Ins** tab. Turn on **Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders**, then press **Rescan**.

In the browser, open **Plug-Ins**. Posy is under **Taddei**.

2 Make the Posy track

Insert a MIDI track (**Create → Insert MIDI Track**, or ⌘⇧T) and drag Posy onto it. Live adds it as an instrument, because that's how it loads MIDI generators. Renaming the track “Posy” makes the next steps easier to read.

Posy opens on set 001, Pop. Its panel opens too; if it doesn't, click the wrench on the device.

3 Make the instrument track

Insert a second MIDI track and put an instrument on it. Anything that plays chords works. Leave it unarmed.

> **Tip** Pads and keys suit Posy best: something with a slow attack and long release turns every pad into a wash of sound. Electric, or Drift with a pad preset, are good first picks.

4 Route Posy into the instrument

Show the mixer's In/Out section if it's hidden: **View → In/Out** in Live 11, **View → Mixer Controls → In/Out** in Live 12 (⌘⌥I). Then, on the instrument track:

- **A** set the first **MIDI From** chooser to the Posy track (**1-Posy**),
- **B** set the second chooser underneath it to **Posy**, the plug-in itself,
- **C** set **Monitor** to **In**.

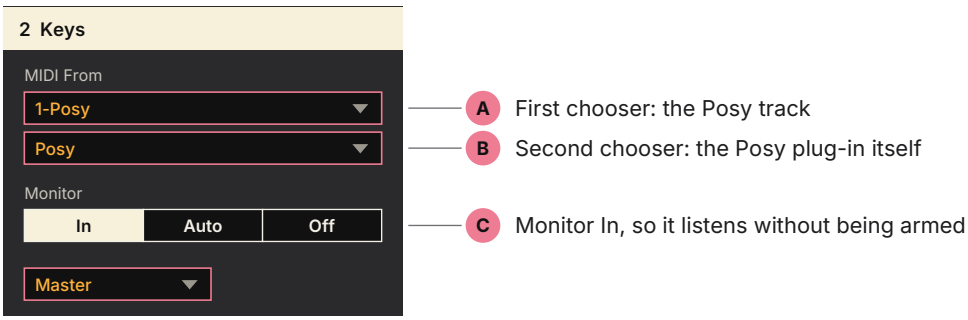


Illustration of the instrument track's In/Out section, not a screenshot. Live's own look differs.

5 Play a chord

Click any pad on Posy's panel. You should hear the chord; the pad turns cream, its name appears after NOW in the display, and the OUT keyboard lights the notes going out. Let go and it stops.

Posy doesn't need Live's transport: it plays whether Live is running or not. Drag across the pads to move between chords without lifting the mouse. Higher on a pad plays louder.

> **Nothing?** The usual culprit is step 4. Check both MIDI From choosers and that Monitor is In. Troubleshooting on the last page has the full list.

6 Play it from a keyboard

Arm Posy's track (or set its Monitor to In) and play your MIDI keyboard. Each key picks a chord: C plays the C pad, C# the C# pad, and so on in every octave. With **KBD OCT** on, the octave you play in moves the chord with it, and the octave from C3 (middle C) to B3 plays the chords as written. Turn KBD OCT off and every octave plays the same chord.

Velocity follows your playing. Mod wheel, pitch bend, sustain and other controllers go straight through to the instrument.

Keys stack the way a mono synth's do: the last one pressed plays, and letting it go returns to the one you're still holding.

Find a chord set

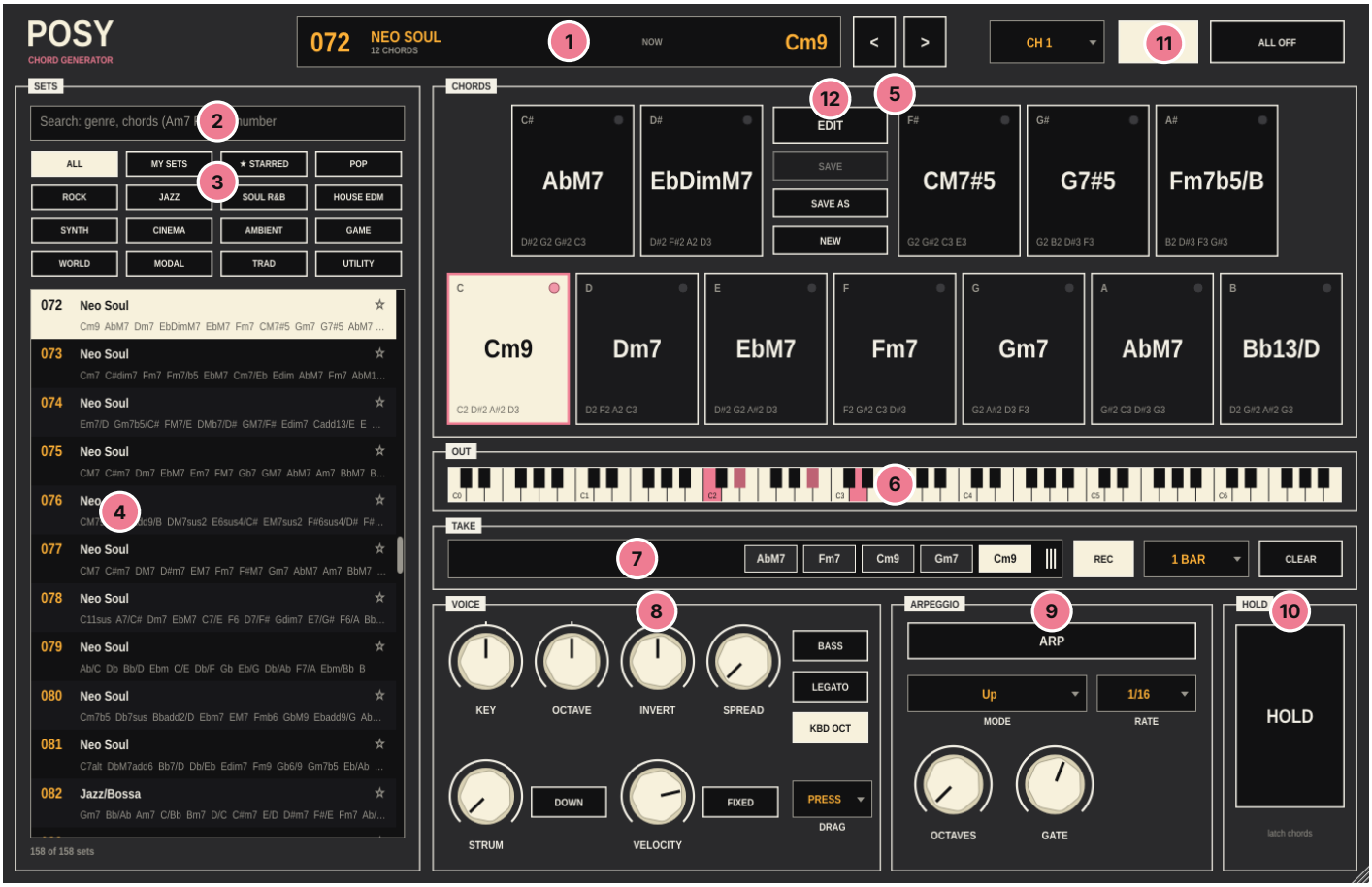
There are 158 sets. Each is twelve chords that belong together: pop, rock, jazz, neo soul, gospel, funk, house, techno, synthwave, film, ambient, game music, world styles, the modes, baroque and more. In sets 101 to 158 every pad's lowest note is its own key, so the C pad plays something over C. Click a row in the SETS list to load it. Type in the search box to narrow the list:

Type	Finds
bossa	Sets whose genre contains the word.
Am7	Sets with an Am7 chord (Am7, Am7b5, Am7/G...).
Dm7 G7 jazz	Every word must match: jazz sets with both chords. A quick way to find a progression.
Bb or A#	The same thing. Flats and sharps are interchangeable, and maj7 finds M7.
/G	Any chord over a G bass.
42	Set 042. Fewer digits match more: 4 finds 004 and 040 to 049.

While the search box has focus, **Up** and **Down** step through the results and load each one, so you can audition sets without touching the mouse. **Esc** clears the search. The genre buttons narrow the list further, and a click on the star at the end of a row keeps that set in **STARRED**. Stars are shared by every Posy on your Mac. The < and > buttons in the header step through the list as filtered.

> **First thing to try** Load set 072 (Neo Soul), then play C, A, F and G#: Cm9, AbM7, Fm7, G7#5. Turn on HOLD and ARP and play them again.

Find your way around



1	Display	The set's number and genre, and the chord playing NOW. Click it to jump to the search box.
2	Search	Genres, chord names and set numbers. Every word must match.
3	Genres	Narrow the list to a family (pop, rock, jazz, world, modal and more). STARRED shows the sets you've starred.
4	Sets	All 158 sets. Click to load; click the star to keep it.
5	Chords	The twelve chords of the set, sharps above. Each pad shows its name and the notes it sends.
6	Out	Every note Posy is sending right now. Middle C is C3, as in Live.
7	Take	The chords you've played, in order. Drag it onto a clip slot (page 7).
8	Voice	Key, octave, inversion, spread, bass, legato, strum and velocity.
9	Arpeggio	Play the chord one note at a time: mode, rate, octaves and gate.
10	Hold	Latch the chord so it keeps playing after you let go.
11	Header	MIDI channel, tips on or off, and ALL OFF to stop every note.
12	Banks	EDIT, SAVE, SAVE AS and NEW: play your own chords onto the pads (page 6).

Shape the chords

Everything in VOICE applies to every chord in the set, and turning a knob while a chord plays re-voices it on the spot. The pads always show the notes they'll send.

Control	What it does
KEY	Transposes every chord by semitones. The pads and the display show the new names.
OCTAVE	Moves every chord up or down by octaves.
INVERT	Rotates the voicing. Each step right lifts the lowest note an octave; left drops the highest.
SPREAD	Close plays the voicing as stored. Open lifts the second note up an octave; Wide lifts every other note.
BASS	Doubles the lowest note an octave below.
LEGATO	Notes two chords share keep ringing instead of being struck again. Smooth pad changes.
STRUM / DOWN	Spreads a chord's notes out in time, up to 200 ms, like a strum. DOWN strums from the top note.
VELOCITY / FIXED	With FIXED on, every chord plays at VELOCITY. Off, the keyboard's velocity counts and pads play louder higher up.

Arpeggiate

Press **ARP** and Posy plays the chord one note at a time instead of all at once. **MODE** picks the order: Up, Down, Up & Down, Down & Up, Up & Down + (repeating the top and bottom), Converge (outside in), Random, and Chord, which restrikes the whole chord every step for rhythmic stabs. **RATE** runs from 1/1 to 1/32, with triplets (T). **OCTAVES** climbs one to four octaves and **GATE** sets how long each note lasts.

While Live is playing, the arp locks to Live's grid and the light beside it reads SYNCED. When Live is stopped it free-runs at Live's tempo and reads FREE, so you can still jam. Changing chord mid-arp keeps the rhythm going: the next step plays the new chord.

Hold

HOLD latches the chord: it keeps playing after you let go, until you play another chord or turn HOLD off. With the arp on, a held chord keeps arpeggiating, which leaves both hands free for the instrument's knobs. **ALL OFF** in the header stops everything and lets go of a held chord.

> **Try this** HOLD on, ARP on, MODE Up & Down, RATE 1/16, OCTAVES 2, GATE about 40%. Play one chord a bar while Live runs and the arpeggio stays on the grid as you change.

Play in your own bank

A bank is twelve chords of your own, one per pad, saved under MY SETS. You build one by playing: Posy listens to your MIDI keyboard and stores each chord you play on a pad.

1 Switch on EDIT

Press **EDIT**, above the E and F pads. If you're on a factory set, Posy starts a bank from a copy of it, so you can keep the chords you like and replace the rest. **NEW** starts with twelve empty pads. The display reads MY and the bank's name, and tells you which pad is next.

2 Play a chord, let go

Click the pad you want to fill (it gets a pink outline), then play a chord on your keyboard. Its notes go straight through to your instrument, so you hear the voicing as you play it. When you let go, the chord lands on the pad with a name, and the next pad is selected: play twelve chords in a row and the bank is full.

Posy keeps the most notes you held at once, so a rolled chord, or a wrong note you lifted and replaced, still comes out right. Chords it can't name show their notes instead.

3 Touch it up

To	Do this
Add or remove a note	Click the key on the OUT keyboard. The selected pad's notes are marked with a dot.
Rename a pad	Double-click it, or right-click and choose Rename. Leave the name empty to name it from its notes again.
Empty a pad	Right-click it and choose Clear. An empty pad plays nothing.
Hear a pad	Click it. In EDIT mode a click selects the pad and plays it.

4 Save it

SAVE AS names the bank and puts it in MY SETS; after that **SAVE** updates it. Turn EDIT off and the bank plays like any set: KEY, the voicing, the arp, HOLD and TAKE all work on it.

> **Good to know** The bank you're using is saved in the Live set too, so a project keeps playing even if the bank's file is renamed or deleted. If you load something else while a bank has unsaved edits, Posy asks first. Right-click a bank in the list to rename it, show its file or delete it.

Get chords into a clip

Posy plays live. Two ways to keep what you played as an ordinary MIDI clip you can edit:

Drag the take

The **TAKE** strip collects every chord you play, in order; the same chord twice in a row counts once. Drag the strip (grab anywhere on it) onto an empty clip slot in Session View or into Arrangement View, on the instrument track. It lands as a MIDI clip with one chord per **LENGTH**: half a bar, a bar, or two bars. The clip has the notes exactly as they sounded, with KEY, INVERT and the rest applied.

Right-click a chord in the strip to remove it. **CLEAR** empties the take, and **REC** turns collecting off and on. The take is saved with the Live set.

Record it

Arm the instrument track. It's already listening to Posy, so arming it records what arrives: record into a clip slot or the arrangement as usual. This keeps the timing, the strum and the arpeggio. Afterwards set the track's Monitor back to Auto to hear the clip on its own, and to In again when you want Posy playing it.

Change sets from the arrangement

Every knob and button is a parameter Live can automate, **Chord Set** included. Pick Posy in the Posy track's automation chooser and draw set changes where the song moves on.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Posy isn't in the browser	Turn on Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders and press Rescan (step 1). Check Posy.vst3 is in ~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3.
The pads light up but there's no sound	On the instrument track: both MIDI From choosers set (track, then Posy) and Monitor on In. Check the track isn't muted.
My keyboard plays nothing	Arm Posy's track or set its Monitor to In, and make sure its MIDI input includes your keyboard.
A chord won't stop	HOLD is on: turn it off or play another chord. ALL OFF stops everything.
Chords sit too high or too low	Turn OCTAVE. From a keyboard, KBD OCT moves chords with the octave you play in; turn it off to keep them put.
The arp drifts off the beat	It locks to the grid only while Live is playing (SYNCED). Stopped, it free-runs (FREE).
The dragged clip is empty	REC was off, or the take was cleared. Play some chords and drag again.

Everything else, control by control, is in the README.